XAU: the central-bank deep dive

Who is buying, who is selling, and why the reversals differ. Global review as of 5 November 2026, Singapore time.

321.2t
Estimated official demand
Q3 2026

120t
Reported official net buying
Q3 2026; source-rounded

100
Official holders screened
Dates and coverage vary

Central banks remain net buyers, but their demand does not guarantee a floor under gold. A stronger official bid can coexist with falling prices when investment flows, the dollar, real yields and liquidity needs change. [1] [2] [13]

1 / Buying has strengthened
China and Poland lead disclosed Q3 additions. Producer-country activity and smaller diversification programmes broaden the picture.

2 / Selling has several meanings
Russia, Turkey and SOFAZ have reduced reported gold. Their transactions do not carry the same mandate, purpose or accounting treatment.

3 / The historic turn was uneven
Europe largely stopped legacy sales; other reserve managers accumulated. SNB is a stable holder. Czechia is a clear same-bank reversal.

4 / Your chart needs a benchmark check
XAU39344-USD maps to a Gold (Derivatives) listing. Its displayed returns should stay separate from spot and LBMA measures.

5 / The investment conclusion. Treat official accumulation as a strategic supporting factor. A tactical entry still needs confirmation from price, yields, currency and investor positioning. No price target or personal allocation has been invented.

Evidence: [2] [39] [41] [47] [24] [27] [7] Facts, estimates and interpretation are distinguished throughout. Figures retain source precision; source-rounded figures are labelled.

Decision implication. The question is not simply whether central banks buy. Ask which institutions, which reporting basis, for what purpose, and whether the market has already priced it in.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Read the report in four passes

A conclusion-first route through the evidence, with a detailed source register at the end.

The evidence Instrument audit, global coverage, quantities and reporting gaps

Who is changing Buyers, sellers, inactive legacy holders and country case studies

Why it matters Reserve objectives, survey evidence, custody, prices and market flows

What to do with it Conditional scenarios, Singapore application, monitoring and audit rules

Six different events can look like a U-turn

Event	Correct question
Sell -> buy	Has the bank changed its desired gold allocation?
Sell -> hold	Has a disposal programme simply ended?
Buy -> pause	Is the bank waiting, or has its long-term target changed?
Buy -> sell / swap	Is the institution raising cash, rebalancing or supplying a local market?
Value rises / falls	Did physical volume move, or only the gold price and exchange rate?
Gold moves vaults	Did ownership change, or only custody?

Use the transaction purpose before judging the direction. A liquid reserve may be accumulated for emergencies and later used during one. A seller is not automatically forecasting a lower price; a buyer is not promising support at your entry price.

Framework: analyst classification informed by [18] [39] [45] [26]. It is a reading guide, not a causal model fitted to prices.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Analysis / inference

First verify what the chart measures

Your screenshots are useful observations, but benchmark identity and return windows need to remain explicit.

Series	Observation	Research treatment
Your 1M screenshot	US$4,106.90; -0.80%	Rolling one-month provider return.
Your YTD screenshot	US$4,110.50; -10.52%	Provider YTD return; 5 Nov, 23:03 SGT update shown.
CoinMarketCap listing	UCID 39344; high US$5,593.01; low US$3,876.37	Exact extrema match the screenshots.
Reuters spot, 5 Nov	US$4,123.39	Separate, dated spot-market snapshot.

LBMA benchmark prices omitted from this public edition.
Open the original source for current benchmark observations.

Sources: user-supplied screenshots; [7] [9] [10]. USD prices per reported gold unit / troy ounce as applicable; screenshots do not establish contractual backing.

XAU39344-USD is the Yahoo/CoinMarketCap Gold (Derivatives) series. Matching the identifier and both extrema establishes its listing identity. It does not establish physical redemption rights, an issuer guarantee or the specification of a tradeable bullion contract. [7]

A quoted gold price is not a universal daily close. LBMA auction prices, a dealer spot quote, a futures contract and a derivatives aggregator can differ by timestamp, venue and contract basis. LBMA sets its gold benchmarks twice daily in London. [8]

Audit rule. Never calculate a drawdown using the screenshot high and a spot or LBMA endpoint. Keep one series, one currency and one return window. The screenshot volume and market-cap fields are not measures of the entire bullion market.

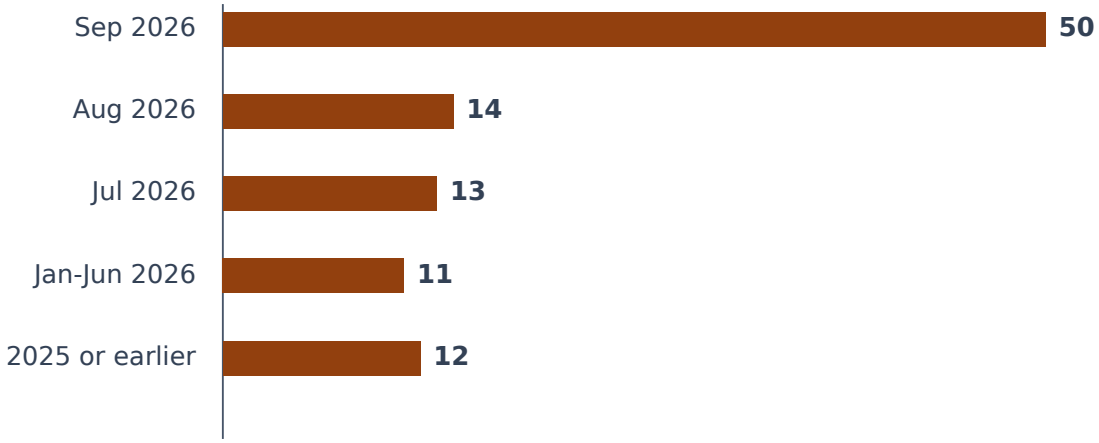
Decision implication. Use a documented XAU/USD or LBMA series for research and the actual product quote for execution. Keep the screenshot as context, not the performance benchmark.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

A global screen still has blind spots

The review screened the November top-100 official-holder roster and cross-checked material cases with current institution-level evidence.

Only half of the 100 observations are September data



Number of roster rows | zero reference shown

Read: each bar counts rows by their stated observation date. Analyst count of [5]. Publication month is November; it is not the date of every holding. The roster includes international institutions and a sovereign wealth fund.

"All central banks" cannot mean all undisclosed trades. The WGC dataset combines IMF reports and other official information, with reporting lags and omissions. This is a global disclosed-sector review plus aggregate estimates, not a claim to identify confidential purchases. [4]

Coverage issue	Consequence
Countries report on different dates	A November table can contain September, August or much older holdings.
Large stocks are often legacy holdings	A high ranking does not prove current buying.
Other official institutions appear	Separate IMF, BIS, ECB, monetary unions and SOFAZ from national banks.
Missing / stale observations	Do not label them zero, unchanged or inactive.

Source-quality control. The public WGC-table copy has an anomalous China reserve-share figure. It is excluded; China volume is checked against SAFE. The table's world total is dated August, so it is not treated as a September flow.

Decision implication. Confidence is highest for reported volume and official explanations. It is lower for the identity of estimated unreported demand and for undocumented motives.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Official buying recovered after a weak start

Central-bank quantity estimates use one consistent publication vintage.

Official-sector demand recovered after a weak Q1



Net tonnes; estimates | zero reference shown

Public edition: the LBMA/IBA benchmark-price panel is not reproduced.

The quantity chart above is retained as limited, attributed statistical commentary. Data: January-September 2026. Source: World Gold Council Q3 2026, publication vintage 3 November 2026. Source [1] links to the original report.

Observed buying is support, not a price guarantee. It can absorb metal while the clearing price falls. A reserve manager may also buy more after a decline. Official purchases alone do not establish the cause of a price move.

Use the latest estimate consistently. The three current quarterly values sum to **675.2 tonnes**. Older reports contain materially different Q1 and Q2 estimates; mixing them creates a false growth story.

Decision implication. A gold thesis needs both an allocation argument and an entry-price argument. The first can remain intact while the second deteriorates.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Most estimated Q3 buying is unidentified

Named-country reports and total official demand answer different questions.

120t	321.2t	~63%
Disclosed Q3 net buying Source-rounded	Total estimated Q3 demand Current quarterly table	Estimated unreported share WGC description

Reported activity IMF and central-bank releases identify named institutions and changes.

↓

Additional estimation Market intelligence captures delayed or undisclosed activity.

↓

Total official-sector estimate Useful for market balance; not a verified list of hidden buyers.

Source: [2]. The reported number is rounded, so subtraction does not produce an audited exact residual.

The September monthly report is narrower still. It records **61 tonnes** of reported net buying in September and **228 tonnes** year to date, down **7%**. It excludes quarterly-reporting SOFAZ. The broader quarterly estimate says year-to-date demand rose **6%**. Coverage differs. [3] [2]

Do not assign the hidden portion to China by assumption. It may reflect several institutions, delayed reporting, non-disclosure and estimation error. An unnamed residual cannot establish a specific country's reserve policy.

A material revision already happened. WGC's July erratum moved **187 tonnes** of Q1 demand from the central-bank category to OTC and other. Total gold did not disappear; its estimated buyer classification changed. [58]

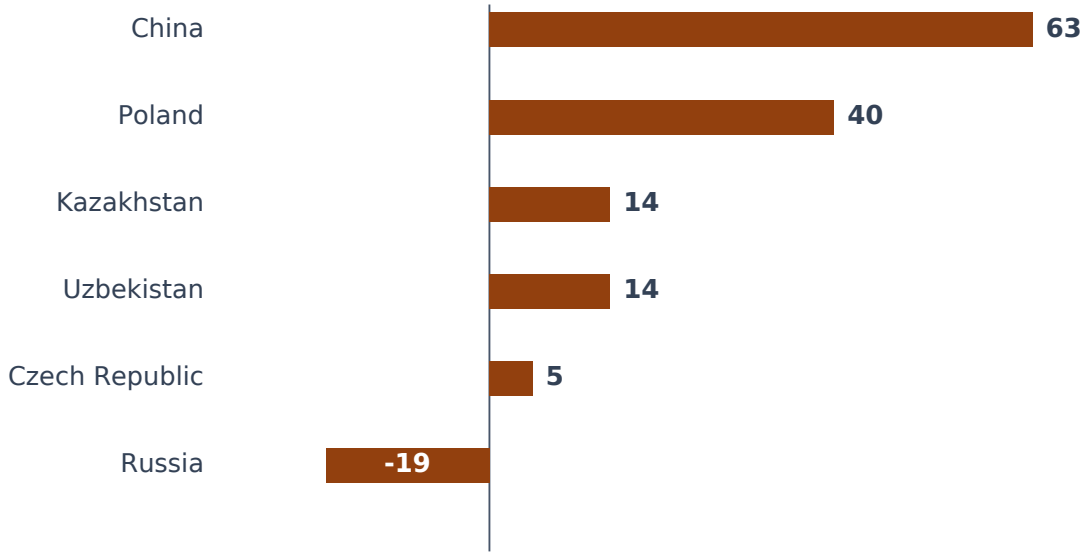
Decision implication. Use disclosed country data to identify who; use the broader estimate to assess scale. Keep the confidence level attached to each.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

China and Poland lead Q3 buying

Selected disclosed Q3 net changes, with source rounding preserved.

The disclosed quarter is concentrated



Net tonnes, Q3 2026 | zero reference shown

Read: right of zero means a net addition; left means a reduction. This selected chart is not a complete reconciliation. Source: [2]. China + Poland are reported jointly as 104t; individually rounded 63t and 40t should not overwrite that total.

Country-level buying reflects different starting positions. A reserve manager with a small gold allocation can add aggressively; another with a large inherited stock may have no reason to increase it. The amount held and the amount being bought are separate signals.

Concentration matters for forward demand. When a few institutions drive the disclosed total, reaching a target or pausing purchases can reduce that component of demand even if no one starts selling. This is a risk to the pace of buying, not proof of a future liquidation.

Latest post-quarter development. On 5 November, Business Insider Poland reported Governor Glapinski saying the **700-tonne** target had been reached. That media-reported update is kept separate from the September statistical cutoff; it is not backdated into Q3. [51]

Decision implication. Track the leading buyers' remaining targets and purchase pace. A target met is a reason to reassess incremental demand, not an automatic sell signal.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Buying extends beyond the largest names

A broader activity map preserves each observation period instead of pretending all rows are current-quarter trades.

Institution / market	Verified activity	Period / evidence
Singapore / MAS	Reported volume +323,268 fine oz	Jan-Sep 2026; primary endpoints
Czech Republic	+11t	H1 2026, WGC June release
Chile	+8t	H1 2026, WGC June release
Jordan; Ghana	+6t each	H1 2026, WGC June release
Malaysia	+6t	Jan-Jul 2026, WGC July release
Bolivia	+2t	Jan-Jul 2026, WGC July release
Cambodia; Indonesia; Guatemala	+2t each	Q1 2026, WGC country report
Serbia; UAE	+1t each	Q1 2026, WGC country report
South Korea	US$250.4m gold ETF stake	End-Jun 2026; securities exposure
Namibia	Domestic purchase agreement	24 Mar 2026; programme announcement

Sources: [34] [36] [42] [43] [44] [52] [54]. Source-rounded tonne changes. Periods overlap: do not add these rows to a global total.

Small buyers can matter for breadth even when they do not set the global total. Repeated additions across different reserve systems strengthen the diversification interpretation. However, an older purchase is not proof that the institution bought again in September.

Planned buying and ETF exposure need separate categories. South Korea's physical stock was **104.4 tonnes at end-June**, as cited in the 1 October report on its planned December purchase channel. A programme or ETF allocation is not yet a new physical-reserve entry. [53]

Decision implication. Monitor physical reserve changes, gold-linked securities and announced plans in separate columns. This avoids overstating both breadth and tonnage.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

The sellers have different reasons

A net reduction is evidence of a change in reported holdings; motivation needs its own source.

Seller / reduction	Observation	What the evidence supports
Russia	-19t in Q3 2026	Governor links reductions mainly to fiscal-rule / National Wealth Fund operations and some coin production.
Turkey	-82t Jan-Aug; +3t in August	Year-to-date net seller, despite a monthly return to buying. Sales and swaps require separate accounting.
SOFAZ, Azerbaijan	200.0t -> 178.1t in Q1; still 178.1t in September	Sovereign wealth fund. Rebalancing is plausible, but the specific sale motive is not established here.
Germany	-1t in Q2, source-rounded	Small technical or minting-related reductions are not equivalent to a broad disposal programme.
Qatar; Kyrgyz Republic; UAE	Small Q3 reductions reported	WGC identifies reductions; no speculative common motive is imposed.

Sources: [2] [39] [41] [48] [49] [47] [40]. SOFAZ change is the difference between reported stocks. The row dates differ and must not be added.

The largest error is treating every seller as a market timer. Reserves exist partly to provide spending or intervention capacity. Using them can be consistent with their original purpose. An institution facing a cash need may sell an asset it still values strategically.

Sell-side breadth matters more than one isolated month. A stronger bearish signal would be persistent, broad reductions in owned gold alongside explicit cuts to desired allocations. The current evidence is more mixed and operational than that.

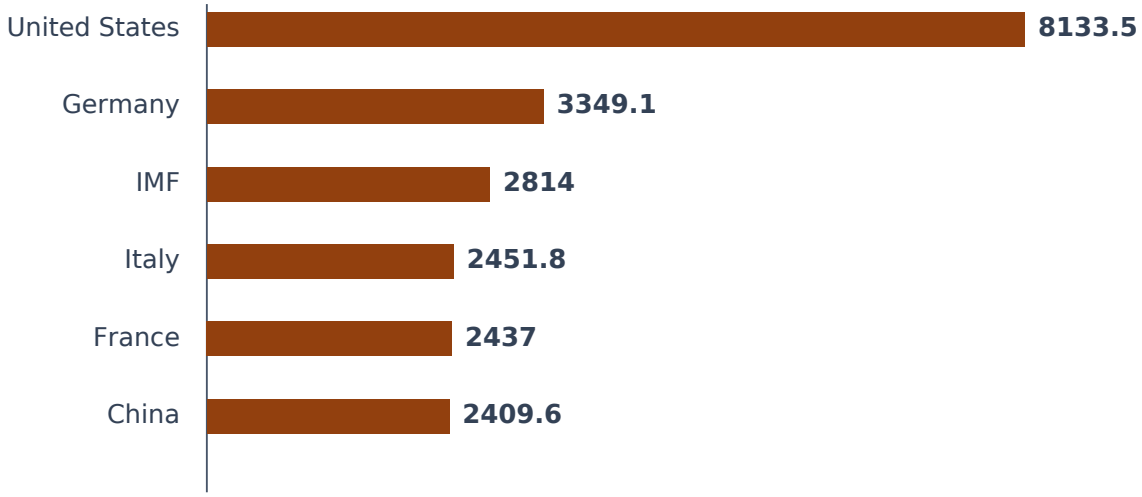
Decision implication. Require a quantity change, an ownership/perimeter check and a stated motive before calling any reduction a strategic rejection of gold.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Large holders are not all active buyers

The inherited stock of gold is concentrated, while current additions come from a different mix of institutions.

The biggest stocks are largely historical



Reported tonnes; mixed Jul-Sep 2026 dates | zero reference shown

Read: these are holdings, not purchases. Selected data from [5]. US/Germany/IMF/China: Sep; Italy: Aug; France: Jul. Custodians and owners differ.

Many established holders show no volume change at published precision. OeNB's December-2025-to-latest-2026 series is unchanged for the US, Japan, France, Italy, Netherlands, UK, Portugal, Austria, Belgium, Spain, Sweden and Denmark. Its other unchanged observations include Ireland, Greece, Cyprus, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, Slovenia, Slovakia, Finland, Romania, Hungary and Switzerland. Dates vary. [6]

The US reserve owner is the Treasury, not the Federal Reserve. The Fed holds gold certificates and the New York Fed provides custody. Gold stored for another country is not a purchase by the vault operator. [21]

A useful counterexample: Canada. Canada's current official reserve report shows no gold. Its reserve framework prioritises liquid assets matched against liabilities. It has not joined a universal gold-buying reversal. [29] [30]

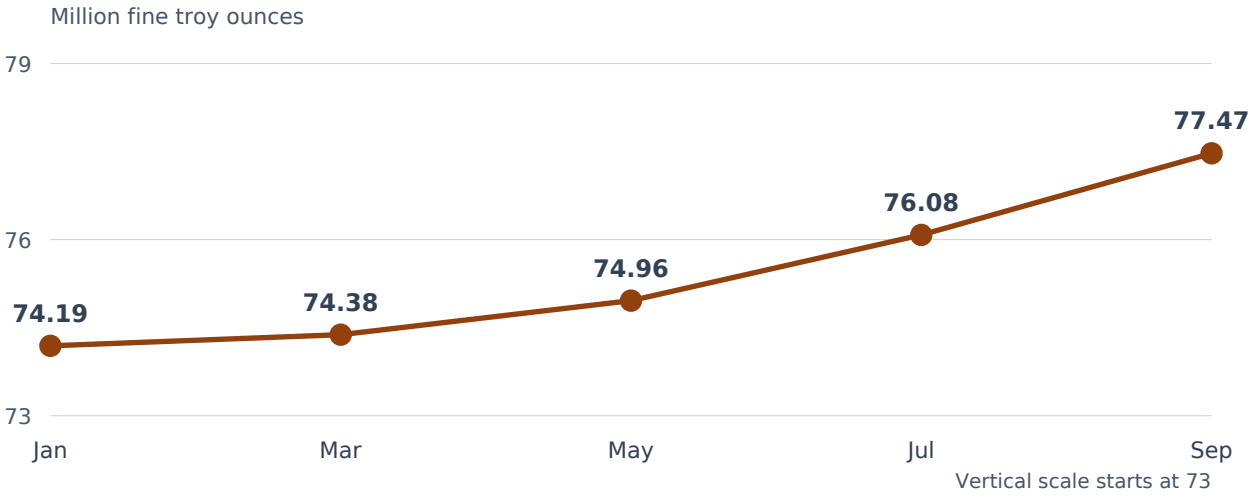
Decision implication. Use flow data to identify active demand. Holdings rankings mainly describe the accumulated past.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

China is adding metal, not just value

Primary SAFE data show the difference between a physical reserve change and a valuation change.

Reported gold volume rises through 2026



Measure	August 2026	September 2026	Change
Gold quantity	76.73m oz	77.47m oz	+0.74m oz
Gold value	US$350.080bn	US$323.517bn	-US$26.563bn

Read: quantity and dollar value can move in opposite directions. Source: [14]. Conversions from 10,000 oz and US$100m retain the published precision. No missing months are interpolated; line displays selected endpoints.

The September value decline is not evidence of selling. The official quantity increased. This is why a reserves headline stated only in dollars can create a false U-turn. Market value reflects both the ounces and their valuation price.

The policy interpretation is strategic, but the motive for every trade is not disclosed. Diversification and geopolitical insurance are consistent with the broader evidence. That does not establish a secret price target, an intention to abandon every dollar asset, or the identity of unreported global purchases.

Pause is not sale. China's earlier pauses in reported accumulation should be distinguished from a lower stock. In 2026, the primary series itself is enough to establish an increasing reported quantity through September.

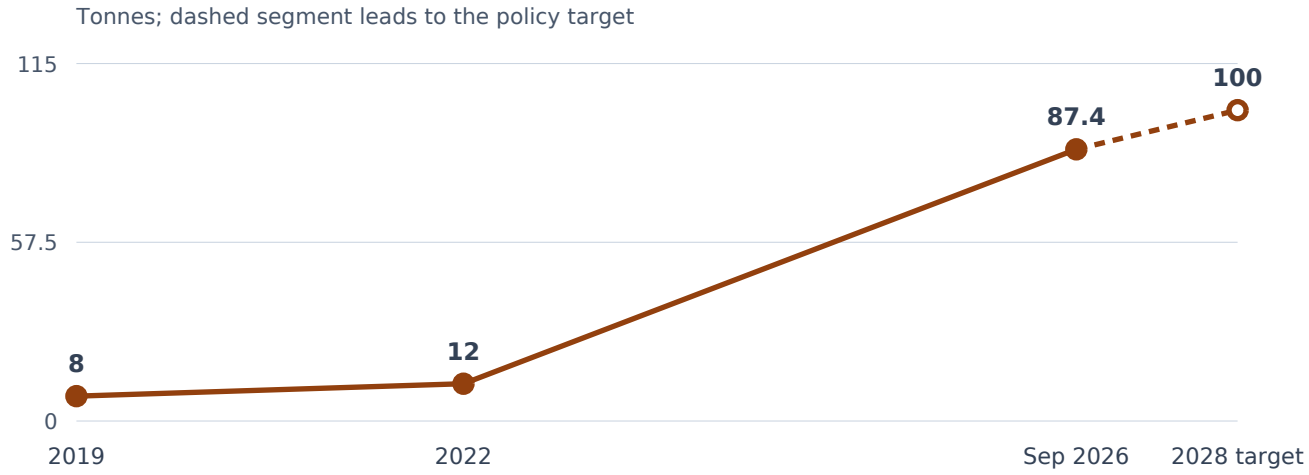
Decision implication. Watch ounces first, then gold's share of reserves using a consistent valuation basis. Avoid reverse-engineering an undisclosed policy from dollar values alone.

Region: China | Institution: PBoC
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Czechia shows a genuine policy reversal

Poland and Czechia both accumulate, but their history, scale and target status differ.

Czech reserves were rebuilt after earlier sales



Read: 2019 and 2022 values are source-approximate; September is 87.4t. The 100t endpoint is a policy target, not a forecasted market result. Source: [27].

Czechia sold most of its earlier stock and then deliberately rebuilt it. The CNB describes an active accumulation programme from 2023, with diversification and more stable financial results among its objectives. This is a real same-institution reversal, rather than a change in the global mix of buyers.

Institution	Latest evidence	Forward question
CNB	87.4t at end-Sep; 100t target by 2028	Does regular accumulation continue to the stated target?
NBP / Poland	672.9t at end-Sep; 700t reached according to 5 Nov media report	What allocation or purchase pace follows the target?
MNB / Hungary	110t after its 2024 increase	Does the rebuilt stock remain a strategic holding?

Sources: [27] [5] [50] [51] [28]. The Poland same-day update is media-reported; the September row remains the statistical reference.

A target can be met without a bearish turn. Once an allocation is built, the next stage may be holding or maintenance. Investors should distinguish the end of incremental demand from the start of liquidation.

Decision implication. Target-driven buyers are useful to monitor, but their future purchases should not be extrapolated indefinitely.

Region: Europe | Institution: CNB / NBP / MNB
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

MAS expanded, trimmed, then rebuilt

Singapore's primary fine-ounce series is more reliable for this question than changes in book value.

Observation	Reported fine troy oz	Change from prior year-end
Dec 2022	4,943,441	Baseline
Dec 2023	7,395,505	+2,452,064
Dec 2024	7,072,034	-323,471
Dec 2025	6,223,213	-848,821
Sep 2026, preliminary	6,546,481	+323,268 versus Dec 2025

Read: net changes in reported volume; not an audited trade ledger. MAS includes gold deposits and, where applicable, swapped gold. Primary sources: [31] [32] [33] [34] [36].

The 2026 direction is a partial rebuild after two lower year-end observations. September alone rose by **6,659 ounces** from August's **6,539,822 ounces**. The reported series does not support a claim that MAS is currently liquidating its gold reserve. [35] [36]

MAS's exact timing motive is not public in the sources retrieved. MOF describes reserve management in terms of resilience and diversification across economic and market conditions. Calling the sales a proven "gold is overpriced" trade would go beyond that evidence. [37]

Vintage and valuation matter. The older WGC 2025 annual narrative used a different Singapore flow figure. The later MAS year-end endpoints are used here consistently. MAS dollar entries are book values; dividing them by today's gold price is not a valid way to recover reserve ounces.

Reserve management is separate from the exchange-rate policy stance. A change in MAS gold holdings does not itself establish a change in the S$NEER policy band. Treat the reserve portfolio and the monetary-policy instrument as distinct decisions.

Decision implication. For Singapore, track the MAS volume line and its definition. Treat strategic diversification as supported; treat undocumented short-term motives as inference.

Region: Singapore | Institution: MAS
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

SNB stopped selling; it did not restart buying

Switzerland is an important counterexample to the idea that every former seller is now accumulating.

2000-2005: 1,300 tonnes sold Legal changes allowed the release of surplus monetary gold.

↓

2007-2008: another 250 tonnes sold Proceeds increased foreign-exchange reserves and rebalanced the reserve mix.

↓

Since end-2008: 1,040 tonnes held The current SNB explanation says the volume has been unchanged.

Read: these are distinct programmes and a subsequent holding phase. Sources: [22] [23] [24]. Volumes use SNB's own presentation.

The original explanation. SNB described capital reserves that were **"no longer necessary for monetary purposes."** This was a mandate and balance-sheet assessment, not simply a short-term gold-price forecast. [22]

Historical underperformance does not explain the decision on its own. A hindsight comparison should account for the interest earned on replacement assets, currency returns, the policy objective and the information available at the time. The gold price alone does not measure execution quality.

Custody diversification is also not new buying. SNB states that its gold is stored across Switzerland, the Bank of England and the Bank of Canada. The location can change access risk without changing the number of tonnes owned. [24]

Decision implication. Classify SNB as a former large seller and current stable holder. Do not put it on a 2026 buyers list.

Region: Switzerland | Institution: SNB
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

The historic turn came in stages

The global change combines fewer legacy sales with additional demand from different reserve managers.

Period / case	What changed	Why it matters
1999-2002 / UK	About 395t sold in 17 auctions	Treasury moved reserves into interest-bearing currencies; BoE executed the auctions.
1999 onward / CBGA	European sales were coordinated	Transparency reduced uncertainty from large official disposals.
After the GFC	Official holdings began rebuilding	Reserve diversification gained appeal in a different risk and yield regime.
2019 / CBGA expiry	No renewal after sales largely ceased	A sell-management agreement was no longer needed; this was not a promise that every bank would buy.
2018-2024 / Hungary	3.1t -> 31.5t -> 94.5t -> 110t	A separate national rebuilding policy, with its own timing and objectives.

Sources: [25] [26] [17] [28]. Historical observations describe decisions at those dates; they are not current trade signals.

The starting portfolio explains part of the apparent contradiction. Some Western institutions began with unusually large gold stocks. An emerging-market institution with growing foreign reserves may start from a much smaller gold allocation. Reducing one concentration and building another diversifier can both be rational.

The world also changed after the original sale programmes. The GFC, prolonged low yields and later sanctions risk altered the perceived insurance value of an asset without a sovereign issuer. IMF research finds an association between sanctions and larger gold reserve shares; it does not prove a single motive for every purchase. [17]

Decision implication. Avoid the narrative "they were all wrong, then all reversed." The evidence shows changed mandates, changed risk conditions and a changing mix of institutions.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Russia and Turkey illustrate reserve use

A strategic insurance asset may be sold or mobilised when cash and market stability become the priority.

Russia / fiscal operations
Governor Nabiullina linked recent reductions mainly to Finance Ministry transactions involving National Wealth Fund assets under the fiscal rule. Coin production also uses some gold. [39]

Turkey / local market and liquidity
In 2023, official accounts describe sales and location swaps serving domestic demand. In 2026, WGC separately reports gold disposals and FX/liquidity swaps. [45] [44] [40]

The mechanism does not require a bearish price forecast

Build reserves Accumulate assets for resilience and diversification.

↓

A liquidity or market need appears Cash, foreign currency or domestic gold supply becomes more valuable at the margin.

↓

Sell, swap or transfer Use the reserve while retaining a longer-term gold allocation.

A swap is not economically identical to an outright sale. It exchanges gold and currency with a future reversal obligation. Depending on the statistical perimeter, the headline balance may include encumbered or commercial-sector metal. Ownership, liquidity and gross custody must be checked separately.

A monthly reversal does not erase an annual net sale. Turkey returned to **+3 tonnes** in August but remained **-82 tonnes** year to date in that release. Russia's governor also contrasted recent operations with its earlier accumulation strategy. [41] [39]

Evidence boundary. The sources do not disclose every counterparty, execution price or transaction purpose. Do not translate a reserve decline into a claim that all the metal was dumped into the international spot market.

Decision implication. Interpret these sellers through their cash requirements and accounting perimeter before applying their actions to a private gold trade.

Region: Russia / Turkey | Institution: Bank of Russia / CBRT
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Producer banks can buy and sell together

Domestic purchase programmes make reserve flows different from a straightforward switch out of Treasury bonds.

Kazakhstan's mirroring mechanism

Domestic mine production A central bank buys locally produced gold with domestic currency.

↓

Reserve choice It may retain some metal and sell some internationally.

↓

Liquidity management It may sell foreign-currency proceeds to absorb the domestic liquidity created.

Source: National Bank of Kazakhstan, 21 Jan 2025 [46]. Diagram explains the stated mechanism; it is not a reconstruction of 2026 transactions.

Gross domestic purchases and net reserve additions are different. Supporting a local purchase channel does not mean every tonne stays in reserves. A producer-country bank can be a major buyer from mines and a net seller over a given reporting window.

SOFAZ observation	Gold stock	Interpretation
31 Dec 2025	200.0t	Starting stock
31 Mar 2026	178.1t	Reported stock falls by 21.9t
30 Sep 2026	178.1t	No further net stock change from March

Primary sources: [48] [49] [47]. SOFAZ is a sovereign wealth fund, not Azerbaijan's central bank.

Rebalancing is plausible but not established as the specific SOFAZ sale motive. A portfolio limit can require trimming after an asset rises in value. The retrieved stock data prove a reduction; they do not prove the manager's price view.

Decision implication. Separate mine purchases, international sales, currency sterilisation and net owned gold. Otherwise a routine operating model can look like a policy contradiction.

Region: Kazakhstan / Azerbaijan | Institution: NBK / SOFAZ
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

The objective changed before the trade

Gold's appeal to reserve managers is primarily about the kind of risk they want to hold.

Issuer risk
Physical allocated bullion has no sovereign promise to repay. That can diversify a reserve dominated by claims on foreign issuers.

Crisis insurance
Gold may retain usefulness when confidence in financial assets weakens, although the protection is conditional and price volatility remains.

Geopolitical access
Domestic custody can reduce dependence on foreign custodians. Market access and sanctions can still limit monetisation.

Portfolio balance
An asset with different drivers can reduce concentration, but a high allocation can create a new concentration.

Domestic production
Local purchase programmes may provide a reserve-acquisition channel. They also introduce operational and liquidity-management choices.

Governance and confidence
A visible reserve asset can carry institutional and public-confidence value beyond its immediate income.

Framework: analyst synthesis informed by [17] [18] [15] [46]. These are mechanisms, not a verified ranking of motives for every country.

The insurance value is an economic benefit even without a coupon. A reserve manager may accept storage costs and lost interest in return for reduced exposure to another issuer or jurisdiction. That is different from predicting the best-performing asset next month.

The same asset can become less attractive when its weight becomes too large. Price appreciation itself can increase gold's portfolio share. A sale to restore balance can follow a successful gold investment, not necessarily a failed one.

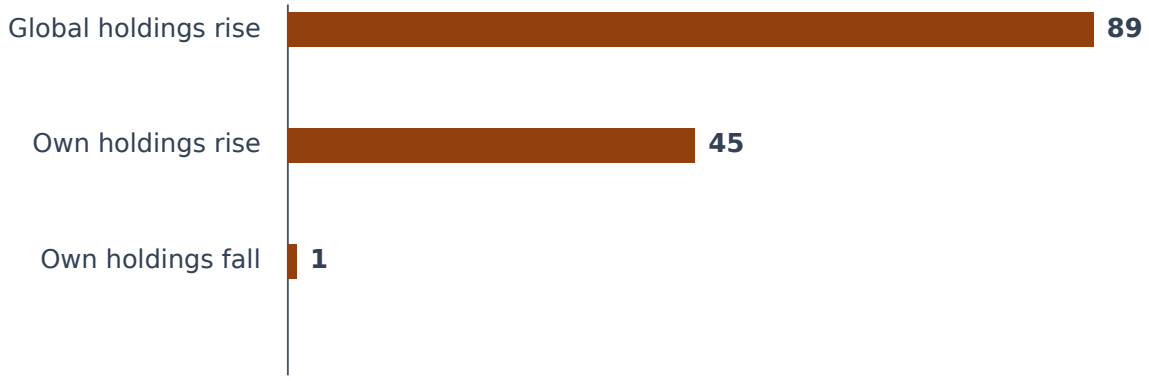
Decision implication. Ask what risk the bank is reducing. The answer often explains the transaction better than a bullish-versus-bearish label.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
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Intentions remain positive, with limits

The 2026 survey supports strategic interest; it does not schedule or guarantee purchases.

Expectations favour accumulation



Percent of respondents to each question | zero reference shown

Read: these are different questions, not three parts of one pie. Source: [15]. 76 central-bank responses overall; fieldwork 5 Feb-19 May 2026; base sizes vary; sanctioned banks were not contacted.

The stated attractions are broader than inflation



Percent citing the factor | zero reference shown

Read: respondents can cite more than one factor. Source: [16]. Multi-select motives should not sum to 100%.

Intention is not an executed purchase. Budgets, market prices, portfolio weights, risk limits and implementation routes can change the eventual amount. Survey optimism is supporting evidence for a strategic theme, not a near-term flow forecast.

The sample is informative but not universal. Voluntary participation and exclusions matter. In particular, do not use this survey alone to infer the behaviour of sanctioned institutions or undisclosed buyers.

Decision implication. Use survey results to judge policy direction. Use subsequent quantity releases to test whether that direction becomes actual demand.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Diversification is not dollar disappearance

Quantity, market value, custody and currency composition must remain distinct.

End-2025 comparison	Market-price shares	Constant end-2023 gold price
Gold	27%	16%
Euro	15%	16%
US Treasuries	22%	26%

Read: ECB's valuation adjustment changes the ranking. These are selected reserve-asset shares, not a complete portfolio; do not sum to 100%. Source: [19].

A higher gold share is partly a price effect. It can rise because gold becomes more expensive, even with no additional ounces. The ECB comparison demonstrates why a market-value headline alone cannot prove a wholesale switch away from dollar securities.

The comparison set also matters. Federal Reserve staff research notes that global gold includes large legacy holders, including the US, while foreign official Treasury holdings exclude US domestic holdings. The paper argues that this weakens simplistic "gold overtook Treasuries" interpretations. [20]

Ownership
Which institution owns the claim or bullion?

Custody
Which jurisdiction and vault hold it?

Liquidity
How quickly and on what terms can it be mobilised?

Valuation
Is the balance reported at market price or book value?

Domestic custody reduces some risks and adds trade-offs. Moving bars home can change access and operational arrangements without adding any gold. Gold can still face market-access constraints; no issuer credit risk is not the same as no risk. [18] [38]

Decision implication. A credible de-dollarisation thesis needs evidence of quantities, portfolio reallocations and transaction currencies, not just a gold-price-driven share increase.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Real yields remain a competing force

Gold's insurance role and its opportunity cost can pull in opposite directions.

3.75-4.00%

Fed target range
28 Oct 2026

2.65%

10-year real Treasury yield
3 Nov 2026 daily observation

Sources: [55] [56]. These are different measures and dates. The real yield is not a same-day XAU quote or a guaranteed return on every Treasury investment.

Higher real yields Interest-bearing safe assets become more competitive with non-coupon bullion.

↓

Higher risk or distrust The insurance benefit of holding an asset without an issuer can increase.

↓

Observed gold price The net effect depends on which demand channel dominates at the margin.

Inflation is not mechanically bullish for gold. If an inflation shock brings higher expected policy rates, a stronger dollar and higher real yields, its opportunity-cost effect can outweigh its insurance effect. If confidence in monetary control instead falls, the balance can move the other way.

Geopolitical shocks also have more than one route. A conflict can generate safety demand while raising energy prices and rate expectations. The direction of gold depends on the combined response, not the headline category alone.

The underlying bullion has no coupon, but lending is a separate activity. Some institutions earn income by lending or swapping gold. That adds contractual, counterparty and liquidity exposure and should not be described as a free yield on riskless metal. [27]

Decision implication. Monitor real yields and the dollar alongside official purchases. Treat each relationship as conditional, not a fixed forecasting rule.

Region: United States | Institution: Federal Reserve
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: Real yield | Status: Reported fact + analysis

The 2026 correction has several channels

September and October require different explanations; lower yields did not automatically rescue gold in October.

Window	Benchmark evidence	Interpretation from the source
September	Benchmark values omitted. See source [57] for September and source [10] for October.	Higher Treasury yields, stronger dollar and lower futures positioning weighed on price.
October		WGC points to de-grossing, rate-path repricing and rotation into bonds; yields fell.
5 November	Reuters spot US$4,123.39	Rebound accompanied a weaker dollar and lower Treasury yields.

Sources: [57] [10] [9]. Spot snapshot and LBMA PM month-end observations are deliberately separated. No connected price line is constructed across the different series.

The decline is not explained by a global central-bank exit. The evidence instead shows that reserve accumulation can continue while leveraged or price-sensitive investors reduce exposure. This is consistent with the larger quarterly official-demand figures and the weaker price trend.

Lower yields can coexist with a gold sell-off. During a flight to liquid bonds, investors may fund purchases by selling other assets, including gold. Deleveraging can also force sales regardless of an asset's longer-term appeal. A one-factor "yield down, gold up" rule misses that possibility.

What the evidence cannot establish. The available data do not assign an exact percentage of the correction to each driver. WGC's attribution model includes an unexplained residual; an economic narrative is not a complete causal decomposition.

Decision implication. The recent rebound is evidence of changed market conditions, not proof that the full correction is over. Confirm the trend with the same benchmark series and fresh flow data.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Investor flows can override the official bid

Keep physical holdings, money flows and derivatives exposure in separate panels.

+19t
October ETF holdings change to 4,275t

+US$2.7bn
October ETF net inflows
Dedicated monthly release

-6%
October ETF AUM change to US$542bn

Read: ETF holdings rose while their dollar value fell. Data to 31 Oct 2026; [11]. AUM decline alone is not proof of redemptions.

Q3 2026 demand component	Tonnes	Meaning
ETF demand	211.2	Physical-backed investment inflow
Bar and coin	267.8	Retail physical investment
Jewellery consumption	312.9	Consumer use, distinct from fabrication inventory
Technology	84.8	Industrial use

Sources: [12] [1]. Selected components only; this is not a complete supply-demand reconciliation.

Derivatives positioning is a separate measure. WGC reports an October decline of **94 tonnes-equivalent** in total COMEX net longs. This is not evidence that 94 physical tonnes were sold, and it must not be subtracted from ETF or central-bank tonnes in a physical-flow waterfall. [11]

Gold trades as a stock as well as a flow. Existing holders can offer metal or reduce financial exposure while new reserve demand absorbs part of that supply. A positive official flow does not tell us the price required to persuade other investors to hold the remaining stock.

Decision implication. The most informative dashboard combines tonnes, investor flows and price - while retaining the units and avoiding double counting.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

New demand can arrive through new channels

South Korea and Namibia show why intentions, securities and bullion should not be collapsed into one statistic.

South Korea	Status by the report cutoff	Accounting treatment
Gold ETF stake	679,765 SPDR Gold Trust shares; US$250.4m at end-Jun	Gold-linked securities exposure
Physical reserve stock	104.4t at end-Jun; reported 1 Oct	Separate monetary-gold balance
Domestic purchase channel	December implementation planned; timing and volume not fixed	Future plan, not completed demand

Sources: Reuters reports [52] [53]. ETF dollar value is a filing-date value, not a current quote or exact bullion entitlement.

This is a genuine change in gold exposure, but not yet the same change in physical reserves. The gold ETF allocation and the domestic bullion plan are separate. Counting the ETF exposure as new central-bank metal and then counting the ETF's underlying holdings again would overstate demand.

Namibia: a new acquisition route. The central bank's March agreement with QKR Namibia Navachab established a domestic gold-purchase framework for reserve diversification. WGC subsequently reported a plan to raise the gold allocation from 1% to 3% by end-March 2027. The target is a reserve share, not tonnes already purchased. [54] [43]

Programme announcements are useful leading indicators. Their market significance depends on actual delivery, the volume retained, financing and implementation speed. A small institution can materially change its own reserve mix while having a small impact on global demand.

Decision implication. Track a pipeline: announced policy, operational start, executed exposure, reported reserve stock. Only the last stages establish realised accumulation.

Region: South Korea / Namibia | Institution: Bank of Korea / Bank of Namibia
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

Use conditions, not an invented price target

The following are analytical scenarios. They have no assigned probabilities or fabricated return forecasts.

Scenario	What would support it	Implication for XAU
Strategic demand wins	Real yields ease; dollar weakens; ETF inflows broaden; reserve purchases persist	A recovery becomes more durable, but entry price still matters.
Two-way consolidation	Official demand remains firm; private flows alternate; yields remain restrictive	Large swings can coexist with a longer-term diversification thesis.
Renewed downside	Real yields / dollar rise; leverage unwinds; ETF redemptions spread; retail demand weakens	Official buying may cushion the decline without preventing it.
Liquidity shock, then recovery	Forced liquidation initially dominates; later policy response and renewed investment demand emerge	Gold may fail as an immediate hedge before regaining its insurance role.

Scenario framework: analyst reasoning informed by [13] [18] [10]. Conditions can overlap; none is a forecast or a promised path.

The strongest bullish evidence would be agreement across channels. Continued reserve accumulation is more persuasive for a tactical entry when accompanied by improving price behaviour, supportive real yields and broader private investment demand.

The clearest challenge to the structural thesis would be persistent policy-led selling. Watch for multiple major reserve managers explicitly reducing desired allocations, not just one month's operating sales or a fall in the dollar value of their stock.

What would change the assessment? A broader disclosed sell programme, sustained investor outflows, new restrictions on gold liquidity, or a prolonged rise in real yields would each require a fresh review. Conversely, a price decline alone does not disprove the role of gold in reserve diversification.

Decision implication. Define the evidence that would change your view before interpreting the next headline. This reduces the temptation to explain every price move with the same story.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Analysis / inference

For Singapore, separate gold and currency

A USD gold return and an SGD investor's return answer different questions.

Price identity. SGD gold price = XAU/USD x USD/SGD
Here USD/SGD means Singapore dollars per US dollar. The quote direction must remain explicit.

Unhedged return identity. 1 + R(SGD) = [1 + R(gold in USD)] x [1 + R(USD/SGD)]
This is a before-cost identity using matched start and end dates; it is not a simulation or forecast.

Decision	What to separate	Why
Strategic allocation	Diversification objective, holding period, liquidity needs	A central bank's horizon and mandate differ from a private portfolio.
Tactical entry	Same-series price trend, real yields, dollar and investor flows	Official purchases are lagged and may be anticipated.
Product choice	Physical title, fund structure, derivative terms, spreads and custody	Different products can reference gold but deliver different risks and costs.
Financing / base currency	Gold return, FX return, interest and margin capacity	These are separate P&L; channels, not one gold-price bet.

A stronger SGD can reduce the SGD return from an unhedged USD gold position. A weaker SGD can amplify it. The multiplication includes the interaction term; adding the two percentage changes is only an approximation.

Gold has no maturity value that must converge to par. A bond investor's "hold to maturity" intuition does not transfer directly. The relevant control is position size, liquidity and the reason for holding the asset, rather than waiting for a contractual redemption price.

Decision implication. Match the instrument, currency and horizon to the actual objective. No personal allocation, leverage ratio or return simulation is specified without portfolio inputs.

Region: Singapore | Institution: MAS
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: USD/SGD | Status: Analysis / inference

A practical gold-monitoring dashboard

Prioritise observations that can confirm or falsify the investment explanation.

Priority	Monitor	Evidence to look for	Cadence
1	Benchmark identity and price	One consistent XAU/spot or LBMA series; confirmed timestamp and product quote	Each decision
2	Real yields and USD	Direction and persistence; distinguish real from nominal yields	Daily
3	ETF / derivatives flows	Physical holdings, regional flows, futures positioning and forced liquidation	Weekly / monthly
4	Named reserve managers	China ounces; Poland target follow-through; MAS volume; Russia/Turkey perimeter	On release
5	Global official demand	Reported versus estimated split, country breadth and revisions	Monthly / quarterly

For a long-term holding, state the role before choosing an entry. Is it intended to diversify issuer risk, currency exposure or broader portfolio stress? Those are different objectives and need different benchmarks and review triggers.

For a tactical trade, ask what is newly improving. A familiar central-bank-buying narrative may already be in the price. Incremental evidence - a change in yields, private demand or market structure - is more relevant than repeating the existing thesis.

For client communication, preserve the uncertainty in one sentence. "Central banks continue to accumulate gold, but gold prices also respond to real yields, currencies and investor flows; official demand is support, not a guarantee."

Upgrade confidence when
Disclosed buying broadens, private flows strengthen and the same-series price trend improves.

Reassess when
Major holders change targets, demand estimates are revised, or prices fall despite supportive macro conditions.

Decision implication. The actionable conclusion is a disciplined monitoring framework. A reserve-flow headline on its own is not an executable investment thesis.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Analysis / inference

The audit rules prevent false conclusions

Data quality is part of the investment analysis, not a footnote added after the narrative.

Check	Applied treatment
Reported vs estimated	Do not identify undisclosed buyers from an aggregate residual.
Latest quarterly vintage	Q1/Q2/Q3 use the 3 Nov table; older estimates are labelled historical.
Monthly vintages	July 23t, August 39t and September 61t come from separate releases. Do not force their sum to equal revised Q3 reporting.
Volume vs valuation	China and MAS use reported ounces. Book values are not divided by spot prices.
Net vs gross	Gross reserve/custody figures, swaps and net owned gold are distinguished.
Plans vs execution	Targets, future programmes and ETF exposures are not booked as physical purchases.
Source anomalies	The rehosted table's China reserve-share anomaly is suppressed; primary evidence takes precedence.
Motives	Official reasons are distinguished from plausible analyst interpretation.
Conflicting source dates	The dedicated October ETF release has the later cutoff; it supersedes the commentary's preliminary flow figures.

Audit sources: [1] [58] [43] [41] [3] [14] [36] [5] [11] [10].

Exact arithmetic is not the same as exact measurement. A difference between published stocks is precise arithmetic on the published data; it can still inherit source rounding, revisions or definitional changes. Every chart retains the relevant unit and observation period.

Visual conventions follow the verified V1.2 Merged pair. Gold uses its approved Energy Amber identity; MAS and SNB retain their assigned colours. Unmapped entities remain neutral. Signs, text labels and outlines preserve meaning in greyscale; all exhibits are drawn as vectors.

Decision implication. The strongest conclusion is conditional: official accumulation remains a material support, while the timing and direction of XAU depend on the wider market.

Region: Global / cross-border | Institution: Multiple official holders
Asset: Gold / XAU | Indicator: FX reserves | Status: Reported fact + analysis

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